of the NAM, and Gorbachev 'found it easier to talk with [Rajiv] Gandhi than with Reagan and some other leaders'. Gorbachev and Rajiv's rapport, allegedly, 'was total, and their discussions were genuinely frank'.[98] US ambassador to India, John Gunther Dean (1985–88), played a critical role in facilitating this channel. In December 1985, shortly after Dean's posting to Delhi, Reagan wrote to Rajiv of the 'deep American desire to see a negotiated settlement of the tragic conflict in Afghanistan'.[99] It was a bluff, but Gandhi took up the issue and, in a public statement made during his trip to Zimbabwe in 1986, sought an end to intervention 'by all parties'.[100] Moscow responded by proposing a four-year phased withdrawal. For Reagan, however, such a long time-frame was unacceptable. Writing to Rajiv in November 1986 (after Gorbachev's visit to India), he rejected Moscow's proposals as 'untenable' and designed to 'legitimise' a 'prolonged occupation and to achieve a thinly cloaked military solution'.[101] This back-and-forth diplomacy between Moscow and Washington via New Delhi reaped no results.[102]

If anything, Moscow lost patience with India and began viewing direct talks with Pakistan as an attractive option. After a damning report of Soviet military performance by Marshal Sergey F. Akhromeyev, chief of the Soviet military, at a CPSU politburo meeting on 13 November 1986, Gorbachev made withdrawal a priority issue (within one or maximum two years).[103] Soon after the meeting, C. V. Ranganathan, India's chargé d'affaires in Moscow was informed about the politburo's decision and sought India's support to ensure stability in Afghanistan after the Soviet pullout. India's response to Gorbachev was 'to hasten slowly' with the withdrawal.[104] An active Indian intervention in Afghanistan, Ranganathan argued, held the potential to further complicate relations with Pakistan.[105] A cautious Soviet withdrawal, thus, was necessary to secure Indian interests in the region. However, instead of having the desired impact, India's persistence to elongate the withdrawal only increased Pakistan's value and convinced Moscow that all India wanted was to freeride on Soviet military presence in Afghanistan to ensure its regional hegemony. In the next politburo meeting between 23–26 February 1987, Gorbachev rubbished Gromyko's warning of India's displeasure with the former's decision to withdraw and, instead, argued that the USSR needed to establish 'direct contact' with Pakistan. 'Maybe we [USSR] should